

Monks, Daily Life & Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 57:18

*Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato
sammāsambuddhassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa*

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

I asked what sort of things you want to talk about. I remember two of them, but I can't remember the third. One was about monastic life, the other one was about daily life, and there was something else, wasn't there? Not me, not mine. Not me, not mine. Ah, yeah, that's a killer that is.

Well, let me start with the daily life one we'll tackle tomorrow, but maybe just say a little this evening. But just to answer a question about monastic life: when the Buddha left home he entered a tradition of his time which seems to have had quite a long history. Maybe it goes back even to the civilization on the Indus Valley, because the Aryans came down from the Russian steppes and either took some of their practices, yoga practices—nobody knows really—but the idea of leaving the ordinary worldly life and to go off and live in the forests and practice these exercises for one reason or another was well established by the time the Buddha came along.

And it would seem that his age, it was a bit like the hippies of the '70s. Anybody and everybody was out there. And when these ascetics turned up at parks, crowds would gather to ask all sorts of questions. It seemed to have been this sort of entertainment of the age, really, on the full moon, in the bright full moon. And so he was just joining a tradition.

And the tradition simply said that you lived really close to nature, in that sort of climate. During the hot season, you might just live under a tree. And they still do it. You still find ascetics out there doing that. And then in the rainy season, you'd build yourself a hut from branches and leaves. And in the cold season, you'd make sure you get a bit more cloth to cover yourself with. So it was a very basic lifestyle.

And the idea was that they would go begging for food on alms round. It wasn't so much that you went and asked people, you would stand in silence. Then hopefully somebody would take pity and the exchange was of course that people thought these were spiritual people whom they could get advice from about their own lives, much like psychotherapists these days. And so some of them were healers, so there was that sort of exchange between them.

Many of them would teach lay people their practices. So the Buddha entered into a particular tradition as opposed to that with the Brahmins. The Brahmins were really the priests in the sense that they officiated at these rituals. They could be landowners, they were advisors to the king, some of them very rich.

And the Buddha often talks about the true Brahmin, sort of pulling their legs, saying the true Brahmin doesn't do that sort of thing. He's supposed to be the spiritual leader of society. And in his district, in his part, the Brahmins really hadn't got to being the top dogs yet. Over towards what we now know as Calcutta, it was the Brahmins were at the top, and then the kings, and then the rulers. But where he lived, the Brahmins hadn't quite ascended to that level and the king still had the greater status in society. So of course he belonged to that caste, he belonged to the ruling caste, the Kshatriya caste.

So when he went out to train he basically took on those traditions and within those times there were people, mainly men, the women did join them, who would practice these absorption states and some of these mortification things. So all this he gathered and he reinterpreted it all when he became, after his own enlightenment, his own awakening, he then reinterpreted all this in a slightly different way to make sense to his own understandings.

So he begins, he thinks he's going to, he wants to share this stuff, so he goes out to teach. And the story is that he meets this monk, he meets this ascetic, his name I've forgotten, on the road there. And the ascetic says to him, you're bright, your face is shining, you're obviously well advanced, who is your teacher? And the Buddha says, to the effect, I have no teacher, I'm the fully liberated one, I am fully enlightened. And the man went, oh yeah, and then walked off. So I think the Buddha quickly realized that's not the way you get his message across by announcing his status.

He then ends up with his own disciples, his own companions rather. But as his fame grew you might say, as he walked around giving his teachings, people would ask him to join him as an ascetic. So his response was "ehi-passiko"—come and come and have a try. So that's known as the first ordination. And after so many people have joined him and many of them became fully liberated as well, they established this *sangha*, community.

And so then there came this taking of refuges which is known as the second ordination where you take refuge in him as the teacher, the teaching he's giving, and the community around him. And then that became the lay ordination. That's what became the lay ordination when lay people wanted to take him as a teacher—they would take these refuges and precepts.

And then they came later on because monks and nuns had all sorts of misdemeanors. So then the ordination became more complicated in the sense that questions were asked. Certain things like you couldn't be in the service of the king. You couldn't be a criminal. You couldn't escape into the order by being a criminal. You couldn't be ill because what happened was one of the great doctors of the day offered free medical care to his order. Well, of course, people who are sick purposefully join the order to get free treatment. They made this rule that you couldn't do that.

So for the first few years we can imagine that they basically would stay with him to get his teachings and to practice meditation and stuff and they would go by themselves and just by hearsay—not having mobile phones—they'd occasionally come across him. They'd hear that he was over there, he's over here, so

they'd go and search him out. As it grew to a bigger size, there came the establishment of monasteries and mainly for rainy seasons because during the rainy season it was difficult to move around for a start but also there was this feeling that they shouldn't move around in case they accidentally trod on little creatures.

Remember the Jains were also very powerful at that time whose teaching was that whether you meant it or not if you did harm like you stood around by mistake you still had bad karma coming towards you. So there was a lot of different teachings around karma and the meaning of karma.

So eventually he had these monasteries here and there and the population grew and it tended to remain fairly close to his teachings which was that anybody who joined the monastery had two duties. The duty to meditate and the duty to study the *Dhamma*, which meant mainly reciting off by heart his teachings. We have the product of that in all the scriptures now, which were 500 years, were just kept by word of mouth.

And there's a lovely little bit where the man called Old Age, is it? I should know this. He's the monk who... Well, I'll tell the story and I'm sure Mario will remember his name. He's an Arahant. He becomes an Arahant and he says to the Buddha, what I'd like to do now is just show people where to stay when they come to the monastery.

So it was said that those people who were interested in meditation, he would put in these quarters, because they were meditating. Those who were interested in the *Dhamma*, the teachings and memorization, he'd put here. Those people who were interested in the *Vinaya*, the rule of the monks, he'd put over here. And the athletic monks, he'd put over there, being the people who messed about.

So people would come to the monastery, especially late at night, when it was dark, to see this phenomena of light coming out from the end of his finger while he showed them where to go. So it's a bit like E.T. if you remember the film.

Anyway, he's quite a character because he also has to give talks to the nuns and the nuns complain that it's always the same talk. Anyway, when it finally comes to him to pass away, he says to the Buddha, it's time for me to go. And the Buddha says when somebody says something like that to the Buddha he always says do as you think fit, do what you think is right. So he rose up into the air, burst into a ball of flame and disappeared. Can you imagine that?

So you can see there that the monastery had certain sections in it which were devoted to certain practices. Later on the monasteries entered into cities. And becoming close to lay people meant there had to be a much more intimate reaction with them. And so there was much more service to do with lay people.

So the monasteries that you see way out in the jungles, well, there's not many jungles left now, but way out in the countryside, they tend to be more specific in their practice. So they're just meditating or they're mainly meditation. As you come into the city, the monastery tends to become urban. So you have monasteries specifically devoted to study.

And then you have small *viharas*—vihara just means a dwelling place of a monk. There were so many on that side of India that the state Bihar is a corruption of the word vihara. So at one point there must have been a lot of them.

And as they came into the city, they had to interact with lay people on a much more religious level. So there came the establishment of little rituals, people coming to take refuge and precepts, sprinkling of water, all those things that were slightly coming over from old Brahminical traditions. Like for instance the string that's tied around your wrist, have you all, you know about that? Yeah, yeah. I'll offer you all that at the end. That really goes back to the Brahmin string that they hold across their bodies connecting them to Brahman, the Brahma.

So these days you have much the same pattern. You have monasteries which are very singular. If you go, for instance, to say, some of the monasteries like Mitrigala in, yeah, Mitrigala, or that's in Sri Lanka, or you go to Wat Pananachat or the Ajahn Chah monasteries, they're all very separate huts and the monks just live by themselves and meditate. And then they turn up for lunch, that's all. Well, it's breakfast. It depends on the tradition that they're in.

So, for instance, if you go up to northeast Thailand, you're out with your bowl as soon as the light breaks. And then when you come back and you have your meal, food's often brought to the monastery. By eight o'clock, you're finished, and that's it. You don't eat it again.

And you might think, oh, God, it's terrible. But in fact, it seems to work. What's that old adage about breakfast being like a king, lunch like a, what is it? Like a prince. Like a prince, that's right. Like a pauper. That's right.

And to my surprise, I found it actually worked. If you eat a load in the morning, and you're not doing much during the day, remember, you're just meditating and walking gently up and down, you've done your exercise, wandering off to get this food, then you find that that suffices.

Other monasteries will give you breakfast and lunch, and it's the same at Mitrigala. I mention Mitrigala because it's a Mahāsi monastery. These places tend to be exclusively for monks and some will have monks and nuns. So they tend to be really for order members, but as you move into the city then you get this connection.

And the Mahāsi, the Mahāsi Sayadaw was one of those monks of the last century who brought the monastic life directly into the urban life. He was actually invited and one of the interesting things about that was that the Mahāsi centre in Rangoon is actually owned by lay people and that's really quite against tradition. Normally all the buildings and grounds that monks live in are owned by them through a trust or some mechanism, but this is actually owned by lay people. And a lot of Mahāsi centers are owned like that.

So here we get a slightly different thing where before that, generally speaking, the idea was that lay

people lived the good life and created good *kamma* so that in their next life they might take on the spiritual life, and the monks and nuns, they lived the spiritual life hoping to attain full liberation.

And this sort of changed during the middle of last century where the meditation techniques were taught directly to lay people with great success through the Mahāsis, especially the Mahāsis, but also Uba Khin and Goenka, people like that. And the same was beginning to happen in Thailand with Ajahn Chah and people like that. So the monasteries then became also places of meditation centers for lay people.

So that's what you've got. You've got, depending on what monastery or what tradition you belong to, you could find yourself in a university. So Peradeniya, for instance, in Sri Lanka, there's a lot of monks there. Basically, they're academics.

There's a sort of mismatch between the real academic life and meditation. Because if you do long meditation retreats, you forget. Because memory is like a muscle. If you don't keep exercising it, it disappears.

So there was a story of an academic monk who came down to the Mahāsi center and was taken by the technique, really liked it. Went back to his study monastery and began teaching the monks how to do it. And they were drawn to it. And then the senior monks thought, no, this is not good. So they kicked him out and stopped it. Because sometimes it doesn't work if you want to really remember stuff.

And then you get these meditation centers now. So the one I was at, Kanduboda, it had a throughput of a thousand people every year. But it also had a monastic sangha, both nuns and monks. And we were devoted mainly to, well, entirely to the meditations and the teachings around meditation. Nobody there you would have seen as a scholar or anything like that.

And then you get all the viharas in cities which really are there to service lay people. So even if now if you go to London there's a Chiswick Vihara which is the biggest Sri Lankan vihara. There's just a continual throughput of lay people coming in either to make offerings or to seek blessings for an exam, or a pending birth, or anything like that. So there's that sort of connection.

And the monks there may or may not study, may or may not meditate. Lay people in the East are very happy for anybody to take the robe and just live the good life. For them, that's praiseworthy enough.

So that's it. There's not much else going on. And those of you who know about Christian monasticism, the ones who we say developed through Benedictine, through St. Benedict rather than, say, St. Francis, will know that there's a routine through the day. But in his rule, in one of his writings, he always saw this as training and that eventually the monk or nun would go by themselves, and to seek solitude. That was the main idea.

Have you seen that Into Great Silence? Have you seen that lovely... Have you not seen that? Oh, yeah. Yeah, the Carthusians in Switzerland, isn't it? French Switzerland? On the border, isn't it? That's really

very inspiring. Very challenging film. Very challenging film. Oh, right. He asked for 10 years, 13 years before the monks gave him permission to film. That's right. Well, they thought about it for quite some time, that's all.

Well, there ain't anybody in. So basically that's the monastic life. And it's not, I remember somebody, I remember this woman asking Venerable Nyanaponika. The very man, I think he was a German monk, very revered and very renowned. He's the one who started the Buddhist, what was it, Buddhist, the Press, what was it called? I say the Buddhist Publication Society in Kandy. His book, by the way, *Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, is still a classic and definitely a good read. And the woman said to him,

because she thought often people think if you're a Buddhist then you must be a monk or a nun—that's the way they think. So she said, "Well, what if everybody becomes a monk or a nun?" And he said, "Don't worry, my dear, it won't happen." And basically that's it. It's a lifestyle and you're either drawn to it or not. There's nothing—I mean, it's not the only way to live a spiritual life. It's an institutional way.

And what makes an institution are the rules and customs. So a layperson who really puts their mind to developing spiritually wouldn't need such tight rules and customs to achieve that, but would simply have to guide their lives as best they can within daily life with the feeling that they're moving forward.

And that in a sense brings us to this daily practice a bit. So when the jewel of the collection is the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse—it's known as the jewel of the whole collection—and the Buddha is giving instruction on how to establish this mindfulness, this awareness, this right awareness. He's been to visit a group of people called the Kurus who lived near modern Delhi. So he's travelling quite a bit. He's travelling between Delhi and all the way over to Varanasi and then up towards Nepal. He's always walking, except in the rainy season, of course, when he stops.

And he gives them his usual talks and stuff like that. And then he returns to visit them and he finds to his surprise they're actually doing what he said. And it said that, for instance, there was no idle talk—in other words, gossip. Around the well you have a bit of a gossip. So he was taken by this and he actually delivers this sermon, this teaching to them. And what the discourse is saying to those lay people: if you want to attain liberation as a lay person, without going through all this ascetic business, this is the way to do it.

So in that discourse, it's basically about the meditation practice we're doing and how to overcome these hindrances—everything we've talked about. But there's also a small section on daily life which really is just mindfulness, it's just being with what you're doing. And when you read the scriptures, it's obviously been adjusted by monks and nuns who were memorizing it, because everything is skewed towards the monastic life. But if he's giving it to lay people, then he must have also talked about cooking and washing and looking after babies and the whole business of how to bring your mindfulness into daily life.

I think the core attitude is service. Whatever you're doing you're doing for your own benefit—so the Buddha is clear about this—you're doing it for your own benefit, you're doing it for somebody else's

benefit, or you're doing it for your benefit and somebody else's. And if you're clear about that, then this is going to be your attitude.

And every time you come to a decision point, and there are many during the day, you just stop for a moment and give yourself the right intention. So we've been doing it with food. Well, I hope so. You've been in front of the food and you've said, "This food is to nourish the body," full stop. The fact that it tastes nice is to be enjoyed, but that's not why I'm eating. I'm eating purposefully for the benefit of this body.

Now it doesn't mean to say that while you're eating greed might not come in and you find yourself shovelling it in. But as soon as you do that you might stop—you say, "Whoa," you put the spoon down. "Okay, stop, stop," and you breathe out and wait for it all to settle. And then you re-establish your right relationship to the food. So you can see if you take that into daily life.

One of the small lovely incidences is when the Buddha turns up and there are three monks there, they're called the Anurudas, as a group around the chief monk Anuruda. And they're three fully liberated monks living together. And he asked them, he said, "How is it you live so peacefully together?" And he says, "Well, what I say is, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?"

Now that works best when everybody is saying that. If you say it and somebody else isn't saying it then you can tend to be abused, so it has to be used with a certain wisdom. But fancy just waking up in the morning and saying, "Well, today I'll put aside what I want to do and do what others want to do." Not as an absolute, but as just a general attitude. So that anytime you meet somebody, anytime you go into a situation, even at work, there is that attitude of openness to find out, well, what do they want to do? You don't have to do what they want to do, but the attitude is that of, "What do you want to do?"

Now normally speaking when you do that and people actually feel your sincerity that you are actually open to what they want to do, they're usually open to what you want to do. And after some negotiation there's usually a little bit of compromise and you end up all being happy. So that sense of openness, that sense of service.

Now again, just like in eating, you might start off with the right intention and then this other stuff creeps in. You find yourself being anxious, you find yourself controlling. And then as soon as you wake up from that, you re-establish your right relationship. So if you think of service as a way of relating both to individuals and to people, that sense of openness to them—and knowing that you don't have to do what they say, you're just open to their suggestion.

The mindfulness that we're practicing really allows us to try and maintain this awakesness during the day. Now when we did that global awareness where you are aware of what's inside and what's outside, so that it's not tight—it's not tight around something. Now sometimes you have to be focused. Like if you're adding up your bills you've definitely got to be focused. If there's something specific that you are reading or studying or looking at or involved in, then there is that sense of focus.

But if you don't watch it, this other stuff creeps in. And before you know it, it's getting tight, it's getting obsessive and all that. Now, one of the things that you can do is always set a time. So you have either a little timer so that it wakes you up every so often. It could be any time—twenty minutes, forty minutes, one hour. And that would be a moment where you stop and you say, "What's going on?"

There's a—you can download a mindfulness bell on your computer, which comes from the Thich Nhat Hanh people in Washington. And you can set it to whatever time you want. So there you are on your emails and your Facebook and all that. And then you get ding. And you say, "Oh," but you don't put it away. That's not what you're supposed to do. You say, "Oh, ding," and you stop and you wait for three bells and then you carry on.

So that business of stopping every so often, depending on what you're doing and where you are, is a really skilful thing to do because you catch yourself. Other times when you feel a bit more relaxed when you don't have to focus so much on what you're doing, try to maintain that global awareness where you're also aware of what's happening in you. So in conversation often we lose contact with ourselves and we get drawn into a conversation. And if you keep in contact with yourself about your reactions to what's happening, just like in the background, often it can stop you saying silly things and getting caught up in somebody else's problems and stuff like that.

And then there comes just a basic routine. Just having a morning practice. The importance of the morning practice is that it sets you in the right mode for the day. Even if you lose it, at least you've reminded yourself in the morning that you want to maintain this sense of awakedness. So what do we mean by that? We just mean that I'm aware of what I'm doing. Everything is deliberate. That I'm aware of the state of my heart—whether I'm in a depressed mood or too excited, I'm getting too excited about things—and I'm careful.

But you have to be careful that you are careful with your words. Speech is so easy to fall foul of. The Buddha talks about kindly speech—always kind speech, honest speech, being honest—and most important to me anyway, at a suitable time. It's alright being kind and honest, but you want to choose your moment. So these factors help us to just be a little reticent about jumping in with our talk. It just pulls us back.

I'll give you one example that often happens to me which I think happens to a lot of people. Somebody might say to you, "My garden's in a mess. Have you got any time to come and help me?" You say yes—say yes. And then after you think, "I don't want to go there. What am I doing? I'm busy." Now you're going to pull back, so you have to phone up and say, "I'm not feeling very well suddenly, somebody's called me," and all you had to say was, "I'll tell you a bit later. I've just got to—I think there's something else on." You just give yourself a little break.

And then when you make that decision, it's coming from a good heart. And if you don't want to do it, you say, "I haven't got the time," or something—"I just don't want to do it." You have to be careful with friends. So it's just little things like that, just to be slightly aware of how we get into conversations.

Now all these things—all these tricks, there are many books on daily life, there are a dozen a penny now—all these things at first feel slightly false, as though you're forcing yourself, as though it's—what's the word I'm looking for—as though you're pretending. So for instance, you might start off by saying, "Well look, before I speak, there'll always be a stop."

Now when you're in the mode of listening and you're actually listening, there has to be a moment where you become proactive, where you've got to answer. Our problem is that while you're listening to somebody you're already giving your answer, and that's where the conversation gets all jumbled up. But if I say to myself, "I'll get in the habit of first of all listening," and then you find that when you really listen there's always a gap before you can actually speak because you've got to change mode, you've got to become active.

So when you practice at first it feels false, it feels forced. But that's always true of anything you do when you want to get into a new habit—you have to go through this process of it feeling practiced, of it feeling forced, of it feeling false. But then once it becomes habitual it becomes spontaneous.

It's the same with *metta*. At first you practice metta and you might not feel like doing it, so it feels false because we think that goodwill has to be an emotional thing. So if I'm depressed, for instance, feeling down in the dumps and whatnot, and somebody comes along and is really happy, they just say they've got this job they always wanted. So I put on this happy face—"Oh, I'm so happy for you." And I'm saying, "No, I'm not. I bloody hate you." Then you think, "Oh, this is so false. I'm being so false with you."

But that's because you're identifying with this down mood. You're not identifying with a part of you that really does want to rejoice in their goodwill, in their good fortune. So at first it feels false. There's a phrase, "Fake it before you make it." I'm sure you've come across that. So you've got to pretend to do it. And then eventually it just becomes natural, becomes spontaneous.

So all these things that you read about, they just take a little bit of effort. Keep reminding yourself. You don't worry about forgetting it or not doing it or getting all jumbled up. And when you get that judging mind come in saying, "You are useless, you'll never do this," you note that as judging so you don't get involved in it. And you just keep reaffirming your right action.

And after a while you find your behaviours begin to change towards the positive. That gives you more confidence. The more confidence you have the more ease you feel about yourself. But even after years of training yourself to respond with kindness and all that, don't be surprised if suddenly you fly off the handle and go berserk. Because those habits are always there. And sometimes we think that we don't suffer so much from that anymore until somebody presses the button. And then we know, "Oh heck, we've still got more work to do."

I remember my teacher said to me that he was very—generally speaking, a very peaceful, very kind man, Dr. Elson Haas. And he would always say to me, "Well, I'm not tested. When I go to the station and these

people make fun of me and all that, that's when you want to see me. Then you'll know how peaceful I am." So it's a case of just gently pushing ourselves, just a gentle push towards what we see as wholesome.

So tomorrow we can see what questions there are, be slightly more specific. Now there was—ah yes, not-self, my goodness. Yeah, that's right.

Well this first of all in the discourse which is the second ever discourse that he gave rather, and in it all he says is he talks about control. Well first of all you have to understand what they meant by the self in those times, or the soul—something which was eternal. It had to be everlasting, it had to be in control, and it had to be happy. If you're in control, if you're in total control of your existence, you should be totally happy because you can make yourself totally happy.

So the first thing he asks is, have a look at what you're experiencing and just see what control you have. So on the body, for instance, sure we can wave our arms about and take it here and there, but on the essential stuff—sickness, ageing and death—there's very little control. You can't grow taller, can't grow smaller, you can't extend your arms. It's like you can't do any of these. So when you look at the body, there's very little control as such.

When you go a bit deeper, you find that actually you haven't a clue what's going on there. I mean, I think it's red corpuscles are now leaking out from the marrow of your bones through the bones into your bloodstream. Have you ever felt that? Have you any idea what your liver's doing now? And even if you knew, could you do anything about it? So when you actually ask questions about what is it you know and can control about your body, you find it's actually not much, it's just surface stuff.

Then he asks the same about our perceptions. When you perceive something, he's talking about the way we see things and hear things.

That's completely dependent on our sense base. If you're hard of hearing, you're hard of hearing. You're not going to hear very much. You're going to find it difficult. If you lose your sense of smell, your taste tends to disappear. So a lot of our perceptions are again based upon the body and also based upon our culture. Sometimes we can't see things because we haven't got the culture for it.

One of the things that happened to me when I went to Sri Lanka was I heard this barking and for some reason I hadn't associated this noise with any animals, and it was way up there in the trees. So I said to somebody, "What is that?" "It's the monkeys," they said. I kept looking at these trees and where the heck are they? The Sri Lankans say, "Well there they are," and I'm looking — I cannot see them for the life of me. Then suddenly I see one monkey in the trees. Of course, once I've seen one, I see them all. There's a whole troop up there. But for the life of me, I couldn't see that first monkey. So you can see how the way we're trained affects the way we perceive things. For instance, the Inuits have something like ten or fifteen different words for snow because they see the various types of snow, whereas for us, snow is snow.

Then there's feelings. Now, the word *vedanā* covers both the sensations in our bodies and the sensations

caused in our bodies by our emotions — feelings, sensations. And what we discover in meditation is that we don't have much control over that either. You can generate good feelings through the metta, but they can't be sustained. They disappear, they arise and pass away, so we don't have much control over those either.

Then it comes to our *saṅkhāras*. These *saṅkhāras* are our habits. Now this is where we could have some control through our will, but we find that we are creatures of habit and we're dragged along by our habits. So you find that our control over habits can be quite minimal too.

And then finally there's consciousness. Now consciousness is dependent on the psychophysical organism. So if that goes, you've no control over it. The obvious time is sleep. You lose your awareness, or should we say your awakeness, in sleep. There's always some consciousness there, always some awareness, because otherwise you wouldn't hear the alarm clock. You wake up by this little tapping on the ear drum.

So that's his first argument. He says, "Well, if there is this soul, if there is this eternal thing, where is it? Where is it in your experience?" He's asking us to look at our experience and see — well, one of the definitions of a soul is that it's in control of itself.

The next thing is he points out this impermanence, which is just another way of saying control — that you can't control it. So he asks you to look at the body and our perceptions and our feelings, all these habits, and even consciousness itself, and see that they're all arising and passing away. So they're not eternal.

When he asks us to look like that, he's not saying therefore that there is nothing, that all there is is this psychophysical organism and then there's nothing at all. That would put him in the category of materialists or annihilationists of his day. So he's not saying that. On the other hand, he doesn't want to fall into the error of saying, "Well there is a soul or a self," because if he does that then he's pointing to something which has some sort of eternality about it, some sort of control. So he's very careful not to fall into the error of a concept about what a soul is, and he's very careful not to go into a complete denial of it.

Therefore he then tries to point to something which is there which sounds very much like a soul. He says, for instance, "There is that which is not born, it doesn't die, it's not conditioned, it's not created." That sounds a bit like a soul, doesn't it?

And then he says there is a sphere. There's another way of saying it: there is a sphere. A sphere as he uses it — we're translating the word *āyatana* — a sphere is a type of experience which can't be mixed with another. So there are six spheres of experience. One sphere is sight, the next sphere is hearing, smelling, tasting, touching and the inner mind. All these are called spheres. In other words, you can't see through your nose. You can try, but you can't do it. So these spheres are quite separate. Then he says that there is a sphere where there's just no phenomena — there's no moon, there's no sun, there's no coming, there's no going, there's no here, no there — but there is this sphere of experience.

And then finally there's a lovely little discourse, a lovely little phrase, which happens twice in the

scriptures. The one I'm thinking of begins with somebody asking him, "Where do the four great elements come to an end?" In other words, disappear, annihilate. Now the four great elements are earth, fire, water, and air. They stand for certain properties. The earth is pressure, weight. Fire is heat and lack of it. Water is cohesion, elasticity and lack of it — stiffness. The air is movement or lack of it. What they're describing is not physics. They're not the way that a physicist would describe what there is in the universe. What they're describing is how we experience matter. So when you go into your body or when you touch something, you'll see it has one of those qualities. All four qualities will be there, but some of them will be preponderant.

The question is, "Where does all that come to an end?" In other words, "Is there an end to all that?" In other words, he's asking about annihilation. And he says that's the wrong question. He said the question ought to be, "Where do these four elements not find a footing?" So where is it that you don't find the world, the phenomenal world?

And he says there is a consciousness — and I'll come back to this word consciousness in a minute — there is a consciousness which is not touched by any of the senses, which is without boundary. You have to have phenomena to create boundary. And in all directions, full of light. And this is the end of suffering. So he's obviously talking about something within us which is not phenomenal. It doesn't belong to this world of phenomena and it cannot be described as a self.

It cannot be described as a self because when you are that consciousness, you don't know it. It cannot be an object to itself. You'll find this in Mahāyāna scriptures where they say things like the eye cannot see itself. It can't, can it? The tongue can't taste itself. Can you imagine if the tongue had a basic taste of curry? It would be a killer, wouldn't it? It's all right if you're eating curry, but what about ice cream? So it's the very fact that senses are empty. They are empty themselves of what they receive.

So this awareness that we are exercising, this *satipaṇṇā*, this intuitive intelligence which we're drawing out of its confusion with the body — confusion with, confusion meaning together — confusion with emotions. When you say "I am," every time you say "I am," you've got to say "who?" Who's angry? With thought especially, very quickly we are the thinker. So we're drawing this quality, this intuitive awareness, out from that to become the observer.

So when you're the observer, the Buddha says, you're in the presence of Nibbāna. You're actually in the presence of the ultimate state. But we can't see it. It's right in front of us and we can't see it. What we actually feel ourselves is to be the observer, correct? To be the feeler. You should all be nodding vigorously. See?

And the double bind is, how do you get out of that? Because every time you want to get rid of that sense of self, another self appears to get rid of it. So you're in an eternal double bind going all the way back.

So the Buddha's instructions are to keep averting away from that sense of self — that's the delusion, that's

the first object we make — averting yourself to actually what it is you're experiencing, because that's only a concept in the mind. It also has a mirror image in the heart as a sense of presence. Often that's described by people as their soul, but actually it still belongs to the world of phenomena because it's a feeling. And if you have a self-image like the observer, that must also still belong to the world of phenomena, to the world of feeling, perception.

So it's by bypassing that, keeping our attention on what it is we're experiencing as arising and passing away — not me, not mine — that there comes the experience of who we really are. Now the Buddha referred to himself as the *Tathāgata*, which means the one who's transcended. So there is within us this Buddha nature, this intuitive awareness. You'll find it referred to in various ways. Really, to experience that in itself is our aim, because once that's known, the path leading to the end of suffering is open wide. That's what it says. But once you know that, then you can't know it.

Now that's the interesting thing, isn't it? Because in your meditation, this intuitive awareness we're exercising — and we're looking at these specific qualities of impermanence, of the role of desire, and of that seeing of not me, not mine — when it sees something, the insight, the actual insight is immediate. There's no thought involved. You either see it or you don't see it. But then it has to tell itself what it's just seen. And that's where the mind comes in. The mind has to be used, the intellect is used to refer back to itself what it has just observed.

That's why often some of you will have experienced it — often in meditation a line will come up, just out of the blue, some insight. There's one beautiful one by a teacher called Ajahn Mahābua who died recently. If you get hold of his book called "Straight from the Heart," these are really beautiful talks, although you have to get into his way of speaking. He's meditating and there just comes this line just out of the blue: "Wherever there arises a sense of a self, that is the beginning of another level of existence, of another level of becoming."

Now, what he's saying there is, as soon as the "I" appears, there's a process that happens. And if that "I" — because of the "I," because of the delusion of "I" — there's always going to be some dissatisfaction involved, because this "I" is always seeking real happiness in the sensual world and it won't deliver. With that insight, he seems as though he really moved. Now that came from this intuitive intelligence telling itself what it's just seen. It happens to us in ordinary daily life when suddenly you say something amazingly wise and you wonder where it came from. You suddenly find yourself giving advice to somebody and you wonder how the heck you came across that.

So it's one of the more tricky teachings, mainly made tricky because of the books written on it. Everybody, any academic worth his salt, writes about not-self. And he just confuses it. Because it's not actually a philosophy, it's a methodology to make us discover what's real. That's all.

And when it came to questions about the soul, there's a lovely one where this man Vacchagotta comes up, and he's completely confused, and he goes to Buddha and he says, "Now come on, is there a soul or isn't

there?" He's obviously had discussions with this and that. He's had discussions with the Buddha and he's finally fed up. He says, "Look, come on, I want to know, is there a soul?" And the Buddha's silent. So he goes away then, and Ānanda, who's with the Buddha, says, "Why didn't you answer him?"

He says, "Well, if I'd have said there is not a soul, he would have gone around thinking that I would have been put into the camp of the annihilationists. If I said there was a soul, I'd have been put in the camp of the eternalists. But I didn't tell him that because if I'd have said to him there was no soul, he would have gone away confused, saying to himself, 'Once I had a soul and now I don't have one.'" So with all these questions, he kept silent.

One of the regular questions was known as the quadrilemma. So we have a dilemma, they had a quadrilemma. The quadrilemma was put as: "Did the Tathāgata upon death continue to exist? Did he annihilate? Did he both exist and annihilate? Or did he neither exist nor annihilate?" You can't get around that one. And of course, he kept silent. He wouldn't go into metaphysics. Because as soon as you get into metaphysics, you get into all sorts of mess.

So, I don't know whether that's made things clearer or made them even more confused. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you by your practice deliver yourself from all these confusions and arrive at that wonderful place of Nibbāna sooner rather than later.

Sādhu. Sādhu. Sādhu.

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